

LEVERS 3-6 OF THE MONEY MAP

The Quick-Start Rate & Fee Playbook

*Six questions, seven fees, one worksheet —
the 15-minute system for your next lender call.*

U.S. HOMEBUYERS • 2026 EDITION

Real scripts, real worksheets, real amortization math.
Backed by the \$500 use-it-and-save guarantee.

A system instead of hope

You're about to do something most homebuyers never do: walk into the mortgage process armed with a system. The real estate industry runs on information most buyers don't have. Lenders know things they aren't required to volunteer. Fine print is written by people who assume you won't read it. None of this is illegal — it's just the default, *and defaults favor whoever wrote them.*

This playbook flips that. Every page is built to be used, not just read: real scripts you say out loud on a real phone call, a real worksheet you print and fill in, real numbers you can check against your own quote.

BY THE LAST PAGE, YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- ☐ Ask the six questions that push a lender past their first offer.
- ☐ Recognize which of the seven common closing fees are worth questioning — and what to say.
- ☐ Compare two or more lender quotes side by side on one worksheet, instead of holding it all in your head.
- ☐ Know exactly what to check on your Closing Disclosure before you sign.

HOW TO USE THIS PLAYBOOK

STEP	ACTION
01	Read it once, start to finish — about 15 minutes.
02	Print the worksheets in Sections 3, 4, and 6. Bring them to every lender call.
03	Use the scripts word-for-word on your next 2–3 lender calls, <i>spaced out</i> — not all in one conversation.

COMPANION NOTE

This is a companion to your free down-payment-assistance estimate. Whatever assistance you qualify for, the negotiation moves in this playbook apply on top of it.

WATCH IT DONE — 90 SECONDS

Before your first call, watch the walkthrough video included with this download: [videos/playbook-27-walkthrough.mp4](#). It shows the whole system — script, fees, worksheet — in the order you'll use it.

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The Real Cost of Not Negotiating

Most buyers negotiate hard on the purchase price, then sign the loan paperwork without negotiating anything at all. That's backwards — the price is a one-time number; **the loan terms compound every month for 30 years**. Here's a real, worked example on a \$450,000 loan (30-year fixed):

	LENDER'S FIRST OFFER	AFTER 2 NEGOTIATION MOVES
Rate	6.75%	6.15%
Monthly principal & interest	\$2,918.69	\$2,741.53
Total interest over 30 years	\$600,729	\$536,950

RATE DIFFERENCE ALONE \$63,779 interest saved over the life of the loan — from two phone calls	PLUS EXTRA PAYMENTS ≈\$420,600 total interest with one extra biweekly-equivalent payment/yr — payoff ≈5.5 years early	COMBINED SAVINGS ≈\$180,000 versus doing nothing at all
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These are real amortization calculations for this specific example, not a universal guarantee — your numbers depend on your loan amount, credit, and rate environment. The math method is what matters: run your own numbers before you sign.

THREE DEFAULTS DRIVE THAT GAP — ALL THREE ARE THE LENDER'S CHOICE UNTIL YOU PUSH BACK

#	THE DEFAULT	THE COUNTER-MOVE
1	Accepting the first rate quoted.	Signal you're comparing offers — the "available" rate changes. (Section 2, Q1 & Q5.)
2	Taking whatever payment structure is offered.	Ask about biweekly or extra-principal options. (Section 2, Q3.)
3	Never asking about prepayment terms.	Nearly all conventional U.S. mortgages allow penalty-free extra principal — almost no lender mentions it unprompted. (Section 2, Q4.)

The 6-Question Script Lenders Don't Love

Every loan officer has a "first offer" — the rate and terms given to buyers who don't ask questions. It is not their best offer. The gap between the first offer and the final one is commonly **a quarter to half a point on the rate, plus waived fees.**

PACING RULE

Use 1-2 questions per call, not all six at once. A rapid-fire checklist reads as adversarial; a curious, informed buyer gets better treatment.

SAY THIS

Q1 — *"Before I move forward, what's your best rate if I lock today versus waiting 30 days?"*

Signals you're comparing lenders without saying so directly.

SAY THIS

Q2 — *"Is there any rate flexibility if I set up automatic payments from my checking account?"*

Many lenders offer an auto-pay discount they don't advertise.

SAY THIS

Q3 — *"Can you show me the full amortization schedule at this rate for both a 30-year and a 20-year term?"*

Forces a side-by-side on total lifetime cost, not just the monthly payment.

Questions four through six

SAY THIS

Q4 – "What prepayment terms come with this loan – can I add extra principal anytime without penalty?"

Standard on nearly all U.S. conventional loans, but rarely mentioned unless you ask.

SAY THIS

Q5 – "I have a competing quote at [X]%. Can you match or beat it?"

Get a real second quote first, then use this — lenders respond very differently to a real number than a hypothetical.

SAY THIS

Q6 – "What fees can be waived if I lock in with you this week?"

Many of the fees in Section 3 exist because nobody asked to have them removed.

ORDER MATTERS

Q1 and Q2 work on any call. Q3 and Q4 work once you're discussing a specific loan. Q5 only works with a real competing Loan Estimate in hand — which is why the worksheet in Section 6 exists. Q6 closes the conversation, after the lender has invested time in winning you.

WHERE THE SCRIPT STOPS WORKING

Two buyers this script isn't enough for

Self-employed? Your file is underwritten on net income after deductions — which often reads far lower than your actual cash flow, and none of these six questions fixes that. **Using down payment assistance?** An inexperienced loan officer can cost you weeks. The Complete Coaching System (\$97) includes the advanced script variants for both — plus the approval scorecard that shows how your whole file is priced before you apply.

The 7 Fees Worth Questioning

None of these fees are illegal or hidden in fine print — they're simply never pointed out unless you ask. Your **Loan Estimate** (the standardized form every U.S. lender must give you within 3 business days of application) lists all of them on page 2.

FEE	TYPICAL RANGE	ASK FOR
Application / processing fee	\$200-\$600	Waived if you have a clean application and are comparing lenders
Appraisal fee	\$300-\$700	Covered as a closing incentive if you're ready to close within 30 days
Credit report fee	\$30-\$100	Waived as a courtesy — the lender's actual cost is closer to \$15-\$30
Underwriting fee	\$500-\$1,200	Reduced to match a competing quote
Document prep / admin fee	\$150-\$400	Waived — largely automated in 2026, little manual labor involved
Rate lock fee	0.25%-1.0% of loan	A free 30-45 day lock — standard at many lenders if you ask
Payoff / reconveyance fee	\$150-\$350	Reduced toward the lender's actual processing cost

REALISTIC COMBINED OUTCOME \$1,000-\$4,500 waived or reduced, asking about all seven with a clean file	WHERE IT LANDS Cash at the closing table — not a projection over 30 years
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Fee outcomes vary by lender, your credit profile, and timing — treat the ranges as what to ask for, not a guaranteed discount. Always confirm final numbers on your Closing Disclosure, which you'll receive at least 3 business days before closing.

Your Action Plan

Three steps, under two hours total:

WHEN	DO THIS
Before your next lender call	Print Section 2's script and keep it in front of you.
Before signing anything	Compare your Closing Disclosure against Section 3's fee list and ask about anything unexplained.
After closing	Set up biweekly or extra-principal payments if your loan allows it (nearly all conventional U.S. loans do).

QUICK CHECKLIST

- ☐ Requested a Loan Estimate from at least 2–3 lenders
- ☐ Asked at least 3 of the 6 negotiation questions
- ☐ Compared origination, underwriting, and admin fees line by line
- ☐ Confirmed prepayment terms in writing
- ☐ Set a calendar reminder to review the Closing Disclosure 3 days before signing

Common Mistakes That Cost Buyers Thousands

THE MISTAKE	WHY IT COSTS YOU
Applying with only one lender	A single quote has nothing to be measured against. Even if you stay with your first lender, a second quote is what makes Q1 and Q5 work at all.
Focusing only on the rate	A lower rate with \$2,000 more in fees is not automatically better. Compare APR (which factors in fees) alongside the note rate — use the Section 6 worksheet.
Big financial moves mid-process	A new credit card, car loan, or job change between application and closing can shift your DTI or credit profile enough to affect approval or rate. Keep still until after closing.
Skipping the Loan Estimate comparison	The form is built specifically for line-by-line comparison. Most buyers never actually put two side by side.
Not asking who services the loan	Your loan may be sold or transferred shortly after closing. Ask where your first payment actually goes so you don't miss it in the handoff.

6 Lender Quote Comparison Worksheet

Print this page. Fill in as each lender sends you a Loan Estimate. The blank column that wins the most rows — at the lowest APR — is your defensible choice.

	LENDER A	LENDER B	LENDER C
Interest rate			
APR			
Application fee			
Appraisal fee			
Underwriting fee			
Rate lock length			
Prepayment terms confirmed?			
Estimated cash to close			
Notes from the call			

HOW TO READ THE RESULT

Don't crown a winner on rate alone. Rate sets your monthly payment; APR captures rate *plus most fees*. If the lowest rate and the lowest APR are different lenders, the fees are doing the damage — that's your opening for Question 5.

Glossary — Terms Used in This Guide

TERM	MEANING
Loan Estimate	Standardized 3-page form every U.S. lender must provide within 3 business days of application.
Closing Disclosure	Final version of the Loan Estimate, required at least 3 business days before closing.
APR	Annual Percentage Rate — the note rate plus most fees, expressed as a yearly rate; useful for comparing total cost across lenders.
Rate lock	A lender's guarantee to hold a quoted rate for a set period while your loan closes.
Prepayment terms	The rules around paying extra toward your principal — almost all conventional U.S. mortgages allow this without penalty.
Origination fee	A lender's charge for processing and underwriting your loan, sometimes bundled, sometimes itemized.

THE GUARANTEE, IN WRITING

Use at least one script or worksheet from this guide on a real lender conversation. If it doesn't save you at least \$500, contact us for a full refund — no questions asked.

This guide wins the phone call. Four things decide everything else.

The Quick-Start Playbook covers rate negotiation and closing fees — levers 3 through 6 of the Money Map. It deliberately does not cover the four levers that operate before and after the call:

NOT IN THIS GUIDE	WHAT IT DECIDES
How lenders score & price your file (loan-level pricing adjustments)	Whether you're quoted the rate on the ads — or a tier below it. Sometimes a 60–90 day pause is worth more than every script combined.
The full 90-day timeline , pre-approval to keys-in-hand	Which week to lock, when to order the appraisal, when your credit must go quiet.
Mortgage math you can do in your head	Catching quote errors on the spot, in the room, before they're locked in.
Layering down payment assistance onto your loan	Whether the thousands in state assistance you may qualify for actually reaches your closing table.

THE HOMEBUYER'S EDGE · COMPLETE COACHING SYSTEM · \$97

Picks up exactly where this page ends

Everything in this playbook, plus: the approval scorecard · rate-lock and float-down strategy · credit-tier repair sequence · mental mortgage math · the week-by-week 90-day timeline · the DPA playbook with verified state directory · low-appraisal and bidding-war tactics · the 12-point closing-day checklist · and the interactive Edge Simulator for running your own scenarios.

THE OFFER MATH

You paid \$27 to win the phone call. The Complete System is \$97 to win the other 89 days — and one avoided credit-tier premium, one correctly-layered assistance program, or one caught appraisal gap is worth more than \$97 by an order of magnitude. The guarantee floor alone is 31× the price.

SAVE \$3,000 OR IT'S FREE

Work the system on one real transaction. If it doesn't find you at least \$3,000 across rate, fees, or assistance, every cent comes back — no questions, no forms. And here's the honest urgency: *none of this can be renegotiated after you sign*. The week before you lock is the week this earns its keep, and that week is already on your calendar.

UPGRADE TO THE COMPLETE SYSTEM — \$97 · SAVE \$3,000 OR IT'S FREE →

Tap the button to get it instantly — shueskills.gumroad.com/1/saueyf. Everything you've read stays yours either way.

The first offer is never the best offer.

Six questions. Seven fees. One worksheet. Use them on a real call this week — the gap between buyers who ask and buyers who don't is measured in tens of thousands of dollars, and it closes one question at a time.

USE ONE SCRIPT — SAVE \$500 OR EVERY CENT BACK